SUPPORTING MATERIALS

Supporting your ideas

A little recap



Remember the initial stages on preparing for your speech

You get an invitation to give a speech, and you're excited.

You need to ask questions about your audience, conduct an audience analysis and determine the considerations you will need to make.

You are either assigned a topic, or you get to choose a topic based on an overall theme.

You determine the purpose of the speech; what is your speech going to do? Do you want it to inform the audience about a topic, event, phenomenon (Informative speech)? Or you want to persuade them to do something, change something, stop/start doing something (Persuasive)? Or you are trying to inspire them, entertain or just for pleasure (Special Occasion)? Or something else?

You do your research, identify your main idea and main points. So, how do you flesh out your main points?

Supporting ideas

Using your supporting materials effectively is essential because it provides detail and specifics.

Imagine you are listening to a speech about why you should develop your digital skills. The speaker says something like "Digital skills will make you stand out in the work environment. Digital skills will also give you the opportunity to be an entrepreneur."

These are his main points, he has dropped wisdom, has he not? But you just there wondering and asking "How? Why? Where? Prove it!" This is where supporting materials come in. We want to know specifics and are not satisfied with vagueness and generalities.

Supporting material can be thought of as the specifics that make your ideas, arguments, assertions, points, or concepts real. Sometimes supporting materials are referred to as the "meat" on the bones of the outline. the points and arguments you are making in your speech may not hold up without the material to "support" what you are saying.

Supporting ideas



Now what?

All supporting materials are not considered equal. Some are better at some functions or for some speeches than others. In general, there are two basic ways to think about the role of supporting materials. Either they:

- clarify, explain, or provide specifics (and therefore understanding) for the audience, or
- prove and back up arguments and therefore persuade the audience. Of course, some can do both.

The overall time for your speech and how much time you've allocated per point will determine how much time you allocate to your supporting materials.

Types of supporting materials

Essentially, there are seven types of supporting materials: examples, narratives, definitions, descriptions, historical and scientific fact, statistics, and testimony

- Examples:

This type of supporting material is the first and easiest to use but also easy to forget. Examples are almost always short but concrete specific instances to illuminate a concept. They are designed to give audiences a reference point. The key to effectively using examples in your speeches is this: what is an example to you may not be an example to your audience, if they have a different experience

- Narratives:

Narratives, stories, and anecdotes are useful in speeches to interest the audience and clarify, dramatize, and emphasize ideas. They can be used in the introduction, the body, and the conclusion of the speech. They can be short, or long but should not comprise large portions of the speech. Narratives can be personal, literary, historical, or hypothetical.

Types of supporting materials

- Definition:

This does not refer to something you can easily find from the dictionary or from the first thing that comes up on Google. First, using a dictionary definition does not really show your audience that you have researched a topic (anyone can look up a definition in a few seconds). Secondly, the audience does not need dictionary definition of basic words.

You only need to define words that would be unfamiliar to the audience or words that you want to use in a specialized way. For example, terms used in specialized fields, often called "jargon," need to be defined and explained

- Description:

Descriptions make the concept clearer. The key to description is to think in terms of the five senses: sight (visual; how does the thing look in terms of color, size, shape), hearing (auditory; volume, musical qualities, how does it sound), taste (sweet, bitter, salty, sour, chewy), smell (what kind of aroma), and feel (rough, silky, smooth).

Description is useful as supporting material in terms of describing processes. Describing processes requires detail and not taking for granted what the audience already knows.

Types of supporting materials

- Historical and scientific fact:

Fact is a truth known by actual experience or observation. You can cite who discovered the fact and how other authorities have supported it.

- Statistics:

This includes numerical facts, descriptive statistics (such as ratios and percentages), and other concepts like mean, median, mode. In using statistics, you are probably going to use them as proof more than as explanation.

- Testimony:

Testimony is the word of others used as proof or evidence. This person could be a professional or expert in a specific field, or someone with a personal experience in the concept being discussed.

THANK YOU ALL SO MUCH, AND WISH YOU THE BEST IN ALL YOUR FUTURE ENDEAVOURS

